humanity' accompanied with a tag line 'it's hard to convey the full depth and range of the trauma, the chaos and the indignity that people are being subjected to; meanwhile, Modi and his allies are telling us not to complain'[25] became common reportage. Another serial critic, Ramachandra Guha wrote a piece titled 'Crisis-hit India needs a leader who listens, not one focused on building his brand'[26]. *The Australian* too published one titled, 'Modi leads India into viral apocalypse' with the tag line 'Arrogance, hyper-nationalism and bureaucratic incompetence have combined to create a crisis of epic proportions, critics say, as India's crowd-loving PM basks while citizens literally suffocate'.[27]

The aforementioned articles just scratch the surface of the scathing, offensive and predisposed narrative that the international media projected of India and the prime minister in a short span of time. The prejudice was so obvious that in a recent survey conducted of media professionals, 80 per cent noted that the coverage of COVID-19 in India by a section of the western media was biased and 71 per cent thought that the stories were not balanced. Sixty-nine per cent of the respondents stated that India's image took a beating by such negative coverage and about 56 per cent said that such reporting may have negatively influenced the opinion of Indians living abroad. The survey also posed questions to understand what media persons thought the possible reason for such biased reporting could be. As responses, 54 per cent thought that international politics was to blame and 47 per cent believed that internal politics in India could have played a major instigating role.[28] In fact, several distinguished international personalities noted the out-of-place, excessive criticism and made it appoint to call it out. For instance, bestselling author, former politician and international policy expert Bruno Maçães noted in a tweet, 'India really gets an odd treatment from global media. I think most people are only now discovering Delta is extraordinarily more contagious. A few months ago it was all about India's incapacities…'[29]

A fact which stood out was that the most derogatory pieces which the international media hosted were written by Indians as opinion pieces; however, that is no excuse to offer space to highly defamatory content for the head of a country. No other world leader in recent times has been subject to this kind of dire press coverage—one insulting opinion piece after the other. Regardless of this well-oiled machinery working in perfect